SpeechGeek



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You may be wondering what's up with the photo of the girl in short sleeves on the cover of the Winter 2007 issue. Oh, you didn't? Well, go ahead and ask yourself that question, otherwise this little rant won't make sense. Question posed? Good. Winter brings to mind cold weather (for most of the country, at least). It's also one of the busiest parts of the competitive forensics season. It's that time of year where things begin to come together: you get a feel for your character, the blocking of your duo is finally solid, and you've (at last!) learned to go to bed early the night before a tournament rather than run that intro one last time. Well, you may want to run the intro once more. It was kind of shaky in practice rounds the other day.

We're happy to welcome Paul Davis back for his second season providing some challenging and wonderful scripts. Paul is an out-there kind of guy, but his scripts pack a punch!.

Corey Alderdice
Publisher

p.s. I honestly don't know why she has on short sleeves. She's probably from Texas. Wait a minute, I know she's from Texas. Whew! I knew there was an explanation somewhere.

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Totally Sheltered

by Bonnie Minkey

Dalia is a 17 year-old, oblivious middle class-type, who talks a mile-a-minute in her own unadulterated stream-of-consciousness vernacular, using her hands a lot, and taking long, sporadic pauses to work out her next ramble. We get the feeling she'll soon grow out of her ditzy phase to be an active, empathetic young woman.

DALIA. So I am like ABOUT to get into the tub—I even had music on in the bathroom okay—and there's this FRANTIC knocking at the door and it's my friend Stephanie—big hippie—and she is like...

STEPHANIE. You have to help me—I just got a call from the women's shelter...there was a fire so they're setting up a temporary thing with cots and stuff in the gym at First Methodist and we need ALL the help we can get, you HAVE to come it's going to be crazy and we really need to get these women inside somewhere because this sort of thing can get messy.

DALIA. Oh my GOD I just wanted to get in that bathtub but I just—I mean I would just look like a totally bad person if I didn't go, obviously. Right? Blugh. So I was like: O-kay.

So I put some clothes on—I mean, I had CLOTHES on when Stephanie came over, but they weren'texactly Rescue Mission clothes—they were way more I'm About to Take A Beautiful Bath—you know: robe-type clothes—well, I dressed and I started to grab some stuff—but Steph said I didn't need any stuff, and we need to GO, so I left my stuff—no purse or anything—which felt totally weird. And I said bye to Emily, my sweet little Pomeranian—oh my GOD she is just so sweet, wif her sweet little face, yes. But anyway, I had to leave her—I was all: I'm SORRY, Emmy, it's Save the World Time, which she totally didn't understand, OBVIOUSLY. So, then we...left. Right, well it WAS crazy in there—the gym at the church. The place was packed—I had no idea so many people had been smushed into that little teeny rat hole of a shelter—WOW. The gym was SO very drab—that terrible khaki paint job they always do in gyms—what is UP with that? Not much of anything to look at, just cots cots cots and all these people—looking really strung out or whatever, I mean FREAKED-out—

NURSE. Hey—Jennica and Sarah are hyperventaliting as usual—I need you, Steph, to get on that STAT; Mallory has a team taking care of assembling all these cots; I gotta go calm down the pastor who lost it when Mary vomited on the entry mat—and the heat is busted, so we need blankets and we need to hand them out cuz we've got a lot of older women out here tonight, oh, and we need to find somebody to be on watch out there in case any sketchy characters try to take advantage of this situation. Who's your friend? Any public health or nursing training?

DALIA. I'm Dalia. I don't really—

NURSE. Okay Dalia, why don't you hand out blankets, bring folks water, and then in about an hour, go ahead and clean the bathroom—supplies are the in closet down that hallway, take a right, second door on the right.

DALIA. (*to Stephanie*) Is she like, serious?

STEPHANIE. She's not "like" serious, she IS serious and I've gotta hustle. Good luck, Dal.

DALIA. I worked really hard. I was running around everywhere. It's like, my whole thing was to get these blankets out of this big crate-thing and pass them out.

So there were just barely enough to go around, which was AWFUL because everyone was SO cold—oh yeah, it was really cold, like freezing practically—so everyone wanted more than one which was really stressing me out because I had to be like—no, sorry you can only have one to these little five-year-old kids and stuff, like:

CARRIE. Miss Lady, I'm fwozening.
DALIA. Aw, here you go sweetie.
CARRIE. Miss Lady, I'm fwozening still. I need anuvoh one.
DALIA. Oh, sweetie, there's only enough for everyone to have one—do you have a friend you could snuggle with?
CARRIE. You?
DALIA. Oh! I've got to pass out water and stuff, but...here—you want my sweater?

I had on this like J Crew sweater—it was totally cute, but like—everybody just—I don't know how to say this—it was just so NOT J Crew in there and I was sort of feeling funny in it even though I didn't really MEAN to dress up or anything, I dunno. It just—I was warming up anyway, since I was totally all over the place, back and forth and back and forth. There were just so many...people...women...I mean it's a battered women's shelter and...so there were lots of women, like LOTS of them, who...they were hurt, you know, bruised up. Broken arms, horrible expressions. Scared. It was so depressing, I just—I could barely LOOK at them, you know? I didn't want anyone to think that I was staring or whatever, and it was just so much easier to keep busy, keep moving. I didn't want to sit still—not just because there was a lot to do, but because I didn't know what to say, or how to act. I just kept finding things to DO, I mean, even cleaning the bathroom was—I mean it was totally gross—yuck—but totally a relief too, just to take a break from all those eyes in that room. These women...it was easier to keep busy than it was to make eye contact with...any ONE of them. I walked around all important, right, like I was on a mission all the time. Here, I go, getting a blanket, gotta concentrate—like I was really making things better and like I was just there to do what I had to do, like I do this every weekend...Volunteer Extraordinarre...but...God, I have argued with Stephanie before—kind of a lot, really—about this whole spending LOTS of time with needy people who really make you really sad to talk to all the time and whether you really owe it to the World or whatever—I dunno—she does this sort of thing like seriously ALL the time—I mean, she's always doing stuff for other people, volunteering or whatever, and I totally respect that, it's awesome. It's just I always have felt like, I dunno, like it wasn't fair that to do the right thing you have to be so...interrupted. I mean it's not like I'm rolling in it and buying the fanciest jeans ever—I mean, I have some nice clothes and stuff, but not a ton—and I don't bug my mom for EVERYTHING all the time like some people do—you know what I mean. But the truth is, if you think of the whole package, my parents and school and money, yeah, and just my life, I guess I AM a "Rich Person." I dunno, this is weird to talk about, you know—why is this so weird to talk about? I dunno, but okay—around all those really, like REALLY poor people I just felt...stupid? (*long beat*) It's just I felt embarrassed.

I always felt like 'here's my life and I'm doing my thing' and to interrupt it to do someone else's thing FOR them was like, stealing mine. Like stealing from the rich to give to the poor! That's how I felt—oh my GOD—when I had to give up that dreamy bath when Stephanie knocked on my door—that she was stealing something from me, my time and...whatever. I was so mad, but that was so lame to be mad, because...I mean—look at me—what do I...NOT have to give? You know?

Well, okay—so there I was, I was handing out blankets and there was this

woman in my line who I dunno—something was wrong with her arms I guess cuz she made this face at me and said:

HANNAH. I can't take it from you just now.
DALIA. You want me to bring one over to you in a minute?
HANNAH. Yes, my cot's over there by the hallway.
DALIA. Okay, I'll bring you one when I'm done over here.

She nodded but she didn't exactly look at me. I was like: did I say something weird? So whatever, I finished handing out my blankets but I saved the last one for her. I picked over to her spot and she was on this little, you know, green cot. She was totally old. She had this crazy thinning hair everywhere and these sad little shoes and stuff. And this bruise—right here on her cheek. I mean—who would hit a little skinny old lady? What kind of creep would—would hit ANYONE for that matter—all these women—I looked around at all these women—I felt angry and hurt—you know, just at the world. None of them deserved to be here. But they were here. And then—also, it was so beautiful to see all these other women who were just there because they knew it wasn't fair. And even though I mostly felt like a big poser the whole time, I was still sort of...proud—to be there, doing my stupid tasks, doing whatever. I found myself thinking: GIVING doesn't feel like STEALING at all...really. You know?

Well, the old lady was totally passed-out asleep and so I just...you know, covered her up—I felt like such a Mom!—I tucked the blanket in around her and everything cause she just LOOKED cold. I guess maybe she was half-awake because she turned around and was like:

RUBY. Thanks, sweetie.

DALIA. And I'm standing there in my fancy jeans feeling so...spoiled and dumb and silly...but she...she wasn't looking at that stuff—she just looked at ME—right in my eyes, right THROUGH my eyes—and she thanked me. That's it. It was a simple thing I did, and it was a simple "thanks, sweetie"—that was it, that's all she said, but it felt...Big. It made me forget all about that bath—bubbles or no bubbles. Seriously.